

FOR RELEASE AT 8:30 AM EDT, FRIDAY, OCTOBER 15, 2021

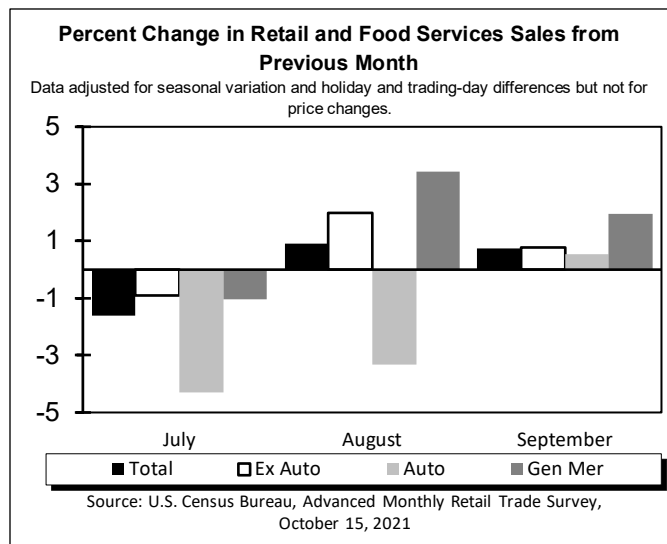
ADVANCE MONTHLY SALES FOR RETAIL AND FOOD SERVICES, SEPTEMBER 2021

Release Number: CB21-160

Statement Regarding Natural Disasters: For information on the impact of natural disasters, including hurricanes, on the compilation of this report, please see the [Weather FAQs](#).

October 15, 2021 — The U.S. Census Bureau announced the following advance estimates of U.S. retail and food services sales for September 2021:

ADVANCE MONTHLY SALES		
September 2021	\$625.4 billion	0.7%
August 2021 (revised)	\$620.9 billion	0.9%
Next release: November 16, 2021		
* The 90 percent confidence interval includes zero. There is insufficient statistical evidence to conclude that the actual change is different from zero. Data adjusted for seasonal variation and holiday and trading-day differences but not for price changes. Source: U.S. Census Bureau, Advanced Monthly Retail Trade Survey, October 15, 2021		



Advance Estimates of U.S. Retail and Food Services

Advance estimates of U.S. retail and food services sales for September 2021, adjusted for seasonal variation and holiday and trading-day differences, but not for price changes, were \$625.4 billion, an increase of 0.7 percent (± 0.5 percent) from the previous month, and 13.9 percent (± 0.7 percent) above September 2020. Total sales for the July 2021 through September 2021 period were up 14.9 percent (± 0.7 percent) from the same period a year ago. The July 2021 to August 2021 percent change was revised from up 0.7 percent (± 0.5 percent) to up 0.9 percent (± 0.2 percent).

Retail trade sales were up 0.8 percent (± 0.4 percent) from August 2021, and up 12.2 percent (± 0.7 percent) above last year. Gasoline stations were up 38.2 percent (± 1.6 percent) from September 2020, while food services and drinking places were up 29.5 percent (± 3.7 percent) from last year.

General Information

The October 2021 Advance Monthly Retail report is scheduled for release on November 16, 2021 at 8:30

Data Inquiries

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a.m. EST. View the full schedule in the Economic Briefing Room: <www.census.gov/economic-indicators/>. The full text and tables of this release can be found at <www.census.gov/retail/>.

EXPLANATORY NOTES

The advance estimates are based on a subsample of the Census Bureau's full retail and food services sample. A stratified random sampling method is used to select approximately 5,500 retail and food services firms whose sales are then weighted and benchmarked to represent the complete universe of over three million retail and food services firms.

Survey Description

The U.S. Census Bureau conducts the Advance Monthly Retail Trade and Food Services Survey to provide an early estimate of monthly sales by kind of business for retail and food service firms located in the United States. Each month, questionnaires are mailed to a probability sample of approximately 5,500 employer firms selected from the larger Monthly Retail Trade Survey. Advance sales estimates are computed using a link relative estimator. For each detailed industry, we compute a ratio of current-to-previous month weighted sales using data from units for which we have obtained usable responses for both the current and previous month. For each detailed industry, the advance total sales estimates for the current month is computed by multiplying this ratio by the preliminary sales estimate for the previous month (derived from the larger MRTS) at the appropriate industry level. Total estimates for broader industries are computed as the sum of the detailed industry estimates. The link relative estimate is used because imputation is not performed for most nonrespondents in MARTS. For a limited number of nonresponding companies that have influential effects on the estimates, sales may be estimated based on historical performance of that company. The monthly estimates are benchmarked to the annual survey estimates from the Annual Retail Trade Survey once available. The estimates are adjusted for seasonal variation and holiday and trading day differences. Additional information on MARTS and MRTS can be found on the Census Bureau website at: <www.census.gov/retail/>.

Reliability of Estimates

Because the estimates presented in this report are based on a sample survey, they contain sampling error and nonsampling error.

Sampling error is the difference between the estimate and the result that would be obtained from a complete enumeration of the sampling frame conducted under the same survey conditions. This error occurs because only a subset of the entire sampling frame is measured in a sample survey. Standard errors

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and coefficients of variation (CV), as given in Table 3 of this report, are estimated measures of sampling variation.

The margin of sampling error, as used on page 1, gives a range about the estimate which is a 90 percent confidence interval. If, for example, the percent change estimate is +1.2 percent and its estimated standard error is 0.9 percent, then the margin of sampling error is $\pm 1.753 \times 0.9$ percent or ± 1.6 percent, and the 90 percent confidence interval is -0.4 percent to +2.8 percent. If the interval contains 0, then one does not have sufficient evidence to conclude at the 90 percent confidence level that the change is different from zero and therefore the change is not statistically significant. Estimated changes shown in the text are statistically significant unless otherwise noted. For a monthly total, the median estimated coefficient of variation is given. The resulting confidence interval is the estimated value $\pm 1.753 \times CV \times$ (the estimated monthly total). The Census Bureau recommends that individuals using estimates in this report incorporate this information into their analyses, as sampling error could affect the conclusions drawn from the estimates.

Nonsampling error encompasses all other factors that contribute to the total error of a sample survey estimate. This type of error can occur because of nonresponse, insufficient coverage of the universe of retail businesses, mistakes in the recording and coding of data, and other errors of collection, response, coverage, or processing. Although nonsampling error is not measured directly, the Census Bureau employs quality control procedures throughout the process to minimize this type of error.

Statement Regarding COVID-19 Impact

The Census Bureau continues to monitor response and data quality and has determined that estimates in this release meet publication standards. For more information, see [COVID-19 FAQs](#).

Weather Information

For information on the impact of weather events on the compilation of this report, please see the Frequently Asked Questions (FAQs) on our website at:

[<www.census.gov/retail/marts_weather_faqs.html>](http://www.census.gov/retail/marts_weather_faqs.html)

RESOURCES

API

The Census Bureau's application programming interface lets developers create custom apps to reach new users and makes key demographic, socio-economic and housing statistics more accessible than ever before. [<www.census.gov/developers/>](http://www.census.gov/developers/)

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Receive the latest updates on the nation's key economic indicators by downloading the FRED App <<https://fred.stlouisfed.org/fred-mobile/>> for both Apple and Android devices. FRED, the signature database of the Federal Reserve Bank of St. Louis, now incorporates the Census Bureau's 13 economic indicators.

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Table 1. Estimated Monthly Sales for Retail and Food Services, by Kind of Business

(Total sales estimates are shown in millions of dollars and are based on data from the Advance Monthly Retail Trade Survey, Monthly Retail Trade Survey, and administrative records.)

NAICS ¹ code	Kind of Business	Not Adjusted							Adjusted ²				
		9 Month Total		2021			2020		2021			2020	
		2021	% Chg. 2020	Sep. ³ (a)	Aug. (p)	Jul. (r)	Sep.	Aug.	Sep. ³ (a)	Aug. (p)	Jul. (r)	Sep. (r)	Aug. (r)
	Retail & food services,												
	total	5,417,238	20.2	606,786	631,060	634,486	530,987	545,307	625,416	620,850	615,250	548,856	537,980
	Total (excl. motor vehicle & parts) ...	4,254,491	18.3	484,353	502,858	500,441	417,929	429,379	502,615	498,708	488,908	434,909	428,168
	Total (excl. gasoline stations)	4,990,382	19.2	555,294	577,811	580,997	493,756	506,577	574,535	570,851	565,769	512,030	501,511
	Total (excl. motor vehicle & parts & gasoline stations)	3,827,635	16.8	432,861	449,609	446,952	380,698	390,649	451,734	448,709	439,427	398,083	391,699
	Retail	4,814,639	19.0	535,845	556,698	558,031	476,247	488,949	553,027	548,654	543,191	492,942	483,422
	GAFO⁴	(*)	(*)	(*)	129,536	127,008	104,834	109,556	(*)	128,219	126,198	112,922	107,143
441	Motor vehicle & parts dealers	1,162,747	27.8	122,433	128,202	134,045	113,058	115,928	122,801	122,142	126,342	113,947	109,812
4411, 4412	Auto & other motor veh. dealers .	1,079,044	29.0	112,882	118,335	124,297	104,451	106,956	113,335	112,700	117,040	105,400	101,093
44111	New car dealers	(*)	(*)	(*)	93,167	98,633	85,909	86,015	(NA)	(NA)	(NA)	(NA)	(NA)
4413	Auto parts, acc. & tire stores.....	(*)	(*)	(*)	9,867	9,748	8,607	8,972	(*)	9,442	9,302	8,547	8,719
442	Furniture & home furn. stores	107,098	32.0	12,593	12,568	12,393	11,071	11,017	12,298	12,273	12,055	10,843	10,812
4421	Furniture stores	(*)	(*)	(*)	6,736	6,759	6,112	5,847	(NA)	(NA)	(NA)	(NA)	(NA)
4422	Home furnishings stores	(*)	(*)	(*)	(S)	(S)	4,959	5,170	(NA)	(NA)	(NA)	(NA)	(NA)
443	Electronics & appliance stores	67,639	30.0	7,577	7,952	7,978	6,459	6,839	8,061	8,131	8,496	6,879	6,986
444	Building material & garden eq. & supplies dealers.....	364,656	14.4	39,236	39,991	41,626	36,930	36,664	39,097	39,071	38,657	36,947	36,692
4441	Building mat. & sup. dealers	(*)	(*)	(*)	35,393	36,781	32,647	32,612	(*)	33,804	33,621	32,007	32,035
445	Food & beverage stores.....	661,741	2.8	74,890	76,263	77,495	69,741	72,353	76,779	76,257	74,630	71,767	71,763
4451	Grocery stores	590,985	2.1	67,001	68,229	68,923	62,100	64,500	68,578	68,093	66,592	63,823	63,861
4453	Beer, wine & liquor stores	(*)	(*)	(*)	5,762	6,230	5,582	5,813	(*)	5,850	5,726	5,790	5,825
446	Health & personal care stores	280,964	9.8	31,492	32,069	31,871	29,462	28,918	32,004	32,459	32,389	29,972	29,599
44611	Pharmacies & drug stores	(*)	(*)	(*)	27,298	27,035	25,237	24,757	(*)	27,518	27,615	26,071	25,236
447	Gasoline stations	426,856	33.0	51,492	53,249	53,489	37,231	38,730	50,881	49,999	49,481	36,826	36,469
448	Clothing & clothing accessories stores	206,649	58.2	23,021	25,872	25,874	18,790	18,968	26,148	25,868	25,776	21,366	18,679
44811	Men's clothing stores	(*)	(*)	(*)	(S)	(S)	401	379	(*)	(S)	(S)	413	411
44812	Women's clothing stores	(*)	(*)	(*)	3,087	3,338	2,494	2,386	(*)	3,249	3,308	2,653	2,498
44814	Family clothing stores	(*)	(*)	(*)	10,376	10,536	7,561	7,768	(NA)	(NA)	(NA)	(NA)	(NA)
4482	Shoe stores	(*)	(*)	(*)	3,939	3,456	2,643	2,822	(*)	3,239	3,282	3,066	2,270
451	Sporting goods, hobby, musical instrument, & book stores	78,477	32.9	8,805	9,808	9,200	7,794	8,218	9,278	8,949	9,256	8,127	7,526
452	General merchandise stores.....	592,528	11.3	66,810	70,672	69,034	58,567	62,304	72,002	70,620	68,273	63,593	61,180
4521	Department stores	94,775	21.7	11,144	12,314	11,728	9,182	9,879	12,560	12,452	12,184	10,567	9,636
4529	Other general merch. stores.....	(*)	(*)	(*)	58,358	57,306	49,385	52,425	(*)	58,168	56,089	53,026	51,544
45291	Warehouse clubs & supercenters.....	(*)	(*)	(*)	50,738	49,580	42,093	45,080	(*)	50,385	48,371	45,310	43,980
45299	All oth. gen. merch. stores.....	(*)	(*)	(*)	7,620	7,726	7,292	7,345	(*)	7,783	7,718	7,716	7,564
453	Miscellaneous store retailers	120,667	27.8	14,010	14,428	14,421	11,604	11,842	14,388	14,133	13,902	11,854	11,669
454	Nonstore retailers	744,617	15.2	83,486	85,624	80,605	75,540	77,168	89,290	88,752	83,934	80,821	82,235
4541	Elect. shopping & m/o houses	(*)	(*)	(*)	77,947	72,804	68,425	70,505	(*)	80,110	75,133	73,026	74,608
722	Food services & drinking places	602,599	30.5	70,941	74,362	76,455	54,740	56,358	72,389	72,196	72,059	55,914	54,558

(*) Advance estimates are not available for this kind of business.

(NA) Not available (a) Advance estimate (p) Preliminary estimate (r) Revised estimate

(S) Estimate does not meet publication standards because of high sampling variability (coefficient of variation is greater than 30%), poor response quality (total quantity response rate is less than 50%), or other concerns about the estimate's quality.

(1) For a full description of the NAICS codes used in this table, see <<https://www.census.gov/naics/>>.

(2) Estimates are concurrently adjusted for seasonal variation and for holiday and trading day differences, but not for price changes. Concurrent seasonal adjustment uses all available unadjusted estimates as input to the X-13ARIMA-SEATS program. The factors derived from the program are used in calculating all seasonally adjusted estimates shown in this table. Year-to-date seasonally adjusted sales estimates are not tabulated. Adjustment factors and explanatory material can be found on the Internet at <<http://www.census.gov/retail>>.

(3) Advance estimates are based on early reports obtained from a small sample of firms selected from the larger Monthly Retail Trade Survey (MRTS) sample. All other estimates are from the MRTS sample.

(4) GAFO represents firms which specialize in department store types of merchandise and is comprised of furniture & home furnishings (442), electronics & appliances (443), clothing & accessories (448), sporting goods, hobby, musical instrument, and book (451), general merchandise (452), office supply, stationery, and gift stores (4532).

Source: U.S. Census Bureau, Advance Monthly Retail Trade Survey, October 15, 2021. Table 3 provides estimated measures of sampling variability. Additional information on confidentiality protection, sampling error, nonsampling error, sample design, and definitions may be found at

Table 2. Estimated Change in Monthly Sales for Retail and Food Services, by Kind of Business

(Estimates are shown as percents and are based on data from the Advance Monthly Retail Trade Survey, Monthly Retail Trade Survey, and administrative records.)

NAICS code	Kind of Business	Percent Change ¹					
		Sep. 2021 Advance from --		Aug. 2021 Preliminary from --		Jul. 2021 through Sep. 2021 from --	
		Aug. 2021 (p)	Sep. 2020 (r)	Jul. 2021 (r)	Aug. 2020 (r)	Apr. 2021 through Jun. 2021	Jul. 2020 through Sep. 2020
	Retail & food services,						
	total	0.7	13.9	0.9	15.4	-0.7	14.9
	Total (excl. motor vehicle & parts)	0.8	15.6	2.0	16.5	1.7	15.8
	Total (excl. gasoline stations)	0.6	12.2	0.9	13.8	-1.3	13.2
	Total (excl. motor vehicle & parts & gasoline stations)	0.7	13.5	2.1	14.6	1.1	13.8
	Retail	0.8	12.2	1.0	13.5	-1.4	12.8
441	Motor vehicle & parts dealers	0.5	7.8	-3.3	11.2	-9.1	11.4
4411, 4412	Auto & other motor veh. dealers ...	0.6	7.5	-3.7	11.5	-9.7	11.6
442	Furniture & home furn. stores	0.2	13.4	1.8	13.5	-0.8	14.5
443	Electronics & appliance stores	-0.9	17.2	-4.3	16.4	-2.3	18.4
444	Building material & garden eq. & supplies dealers.....	0.1	5.8	1.1	6.5	-3.3	6.6
445	Food & beverage stores.....	0.7	7.0	2.2	6.3	2.1	5.3
4451	Grocery stores	0.7	7.5	2.3	6.6	2.7	5.5
446	Health & personal care stores	-1.4	6.8	0.2	9.7	1.1	8.4
447	Gasoline stations	1.8	38.2	1.0	37.1	6.8	37.6
448	Clothing & clothing accessories stores	1.1	22.4	0.4	38.5	1.4	33.9
451	Sporting goods, hobby, musical instrument, & book stores	3.7	14.2	-3.3	18.9	-4.5	15.7
452	General merchandise stores.....	2.0	13.2	3.4	15.4	2.5	13.1
4521	Department stores	0.9	18.9	2.2	29.2	6.8	24.3
453	Miscellaneous store retailers	1.8	21.4	1.7	21.1	4.7	21.1
454	Nonstore retailers	0.6	10.5	5.7	7.9	-1.1	7.5
722	Food services & drinking places	0.3	29.5	0.2	32.3	4.7	33.2

(p) Preliminary estimate (r) Revised estimate

(1) Estimates shown in this table are derived from adjusted estimates provided in Table 1 of this report.

Source: U.S. Census Bureau, Advance Monthly Retail Trade Survey, October 15, 2021. Table 3 provides estimated measures of sampling variability.

Additional information on confidentiality protection, sampling error, nonsampling error, sample design, and definitions may be found at
<www.census.gov/retail/how_surveys_are_collected.html>.

Table 3. Estimated Measures of Sampling Variability and Revision to Advance Estimates Sep. 2021

(Estimates are shown as percents and are based on data from the Advance Monthly Retail Trade Survey and Monthly Retail Trade Survey)

NAICS Code	Kind of Business	Median CV Current Mo. (%)	Median standard error Percent change			Revision for month- to-month change	
			Previous Mo. to Current Mo.	Previous Qtr. to Current Qtr.	Current Mo. to same Mo. Last Yr.	Average revision	Median absolute revision
	Retail & food services,						
	total	0.7	0.3	0.2	0.4	0.2	0.3
	Total (excl. motor vehicle & parts)	0.9	0.2	0.2	0.4	0.2	0.4
	Total (excl. gasoline stations)	0.7	0.3	0.2	0.5	0.2	0.4
	Total (excl. motor vehicle & parts & gasoline stations)	0.9	0.3	0.2	0.4	0.2	0.5
	Retail, total	0.6	0.2	0.2	0.4	0.2	0.4
441	Motor vehicle & parts dealers	1.4	0.8	0.5	1.3	0.4	0.6
4411, 4412	Auto & other motor veh. dealers	1.4	0.8	0.6	1.4	0.4	0.6
442	Furniture & home furn. stores.....	2.9	1.0	0.7	1.6	0.3	1.0
443	Electronics & appliance stores	1.7	0.7	0.5	1.2	-0.4	1.7
444	Building material & garden eq. & supplies dealers.....	2.3	0.8	0.6	1.4	-0.2	0.7
445	Food & beverage stores.....	0.6	0.2	0.2	0.6	0.0	0.1
4451	Grocery stores	0.7	0.1	0.2	0.6	0.0	0.3
446	Health & personal care stores	3.3	0.8	0.4	1.8	0.2	0.6
447	Gasoline stations	1.2	0.4	0.4	0.9	0.3	0.5
448	Clothing & clothing accessories stores	2.3	0.8	0.9	1.8	0.8	0.8
451	Sporting goods, hobby, musical instrument, & book stores	2.8	0.7	0.9	2.0	0.5	0.9
452	General merchandise stores.....	1.0	0.1	0.1	0.3	0.5	0.5
4521	Department stores	0.0	0.0	0.0	0.0	0.0	0.2
453	Miscellaneous store retailers	4.4	2.7	1.7	4.5	0.5	0.9
454	Nonstore retailers	1.6	0.4	0.4	1.0	-0.1	1.5
722	Food services & drinking places	3.5	1.0	0.7	2.1	0.6	0.4

(1) Estimated measures of sampling variability are based on estimates not adjusted for seasonal variation or holiday or trading day variation. Medians are based on estimates for the most recent 12 months.

(2) These columns provide measures of the difference between the advance-to-preliminary and preliminary-to-final estimates of month-to-month change for the same pair of months as measured by the Advance sample and MRTS sample. The average and median revisions are based on estimates for the most recent 12 months.

 Source: U.S. Census Bureau, Advance Monthly Retail Trade Survey, October 15, 2021. Additional information on confidentiality protection, sampling error, nonsampling error, sample design, and definitions may be found at <www.census.gov/retail/how_surveys_are_collected.html>.